

Unit Introduction

In this unit, we focus on ways in which we can help to implement the rights of children in our community. We will look at what citizenship means, and how communities can help enforce rights through mediation and community participation. We consider some strategies to advocate for changes to laws that do not fully protect the rights of children.

Who Is Responsible for Realising Children's Rights?

Of course, the answer is that we are all responsible for realising children's rights. Let us look at how we are all responsible for children's rights. The diagram below shows the layers of people who have an influence on children's lives and responsibilities towards children:

These layers are similar to systems of relationships and context that affect the wellbeing of a child that we were introduced to in the onion theory in Module 1. We will use this diagram to discuss what we can do to protect children's rights. At each level, we will also have some examples of children's responsibilities.

Level 1: The Child

The first level, at the centre of the circle, is the child. We have responsibilities to ensure that children are safe from abuse or mistreatment, have food, clothing, and are in school.

Level 2: The Family

The second level of the circle is the family surrounding the child. This is the inner circle, which includes parents, siblings (brothers and sisters), and close extended family (like grandparents, aunts, uncles and cousins). Parents or legal guardians have the first and most important responsibility for children. They must provide for their basic needs and protect their rights.

Where parents or guardians cannot care for a child, the CRC says that the state (government) must help. For example, if a parent is unemployed and does not have any money for food, then the government should help by providing a social grant to the family. If a child does not have a parent or guardian because they have died or abandoned the child, then the government must help by placing the child in alternative care, for example by arranging

for the child to be adopted, fostered or placed in an institution (such as a children's home) or a group care home.

Level 3: The Community

The community circle includes the school and religious institutions such as a church or mosque, neighbourhood and friends. All of these structures support children and have responsibilities to ensure that children's rights are realised.

Level 4: Partner Institutions

These are NGOs, CBOs and faith-based organisations which support people and governments in realising people's rights. In Unit 2 we learnt about ways in which NGOs support children and communities and how they must include an understanding of rights in the way in which they work. Partner institutions also include the media (newspapers, TV, radio) which help to educate people about human rights and to spread information about human rights. The media can help people know more about their rights; tell people what to do to get rights; and create a place for people to talk about rights. The media can also report stories of human rights abuse.

Level 5: Government

The government is the governing body of a country, and we have spoken about their responsibilities to children's rights. Let's take a look at systems or offices in the government and how each of these offices plays a role in addressing children's rights and child protection. As a development facilitator, you must know how the offices work so that you can learn how to work for change. While every government is unique, these offices are similar across countries. You should know how your government is different from the offices listed here.

Learning Activity 4.1: Your Government's Approach

Think about your government: does your government follow a human rights approach? Consider the following:

- Is your country a democracy with multiple political parties?
- Does your government provide basic services (education, health, child protection)?
- Does your government promote civic participation and provide accessible government structures?
- Does your government discriminate against specific groups (e.g., LGBTQ+ individuals)?
- Does your government empower people through community meetings and free speech?

Community Participation

Let us look at how we can encourage more people to become involved in making sure that children's rights are met. First, we will look at the idea of 'citizenship'.

Citizenship involves being a committed member of the community and participating in community issues and activities to improve the well-being of all. It includes being politically active, voting, and helping to solve problems that affect people.

- **Citizenship:** The duties and responsibilities that people have in their country.
- **Civic Participation:** Community service, attending public meetings, fundraising, or starting task forces.
- **Fundraising Activities:** Events like concerts and plays where the money made is used for a special project.

Learning Activity 4.2: Rate Your Own Citizenship!

Look at the table above.

1. Give yourself a score between 1 and 10 for your knowledge and understanding.
2. Identify your strongest skills and where you need more work.
3. Compare your values and attitudes to those listed.

Participation

The concept of **Ubuntu** ('Umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu') means 'You are because others are'. It is at the heart of citizenship and civic participation. Meeting the needs of children at risk calls for the combined work of all members of society.

Participation of Youth

Young people are our future leaders. Below is a guide for youth participation in NGO work.

Advocacy

Advocacy means working for change. it involves actions taken by groups or individuals to persuade those responsible to change policies and practices.

Advocacy Examples

Abubacer's Story (Mozambique)

During the war in Mozambique, thousands of children were displaced or forced to be soldiers. Abubacer decided to act, helping children trace their parents and providing basic needs like food and medicine, despite the danger.

Freedom's Story (Ivory Coast)

Freedom fought for democracy and freedom of the press in Ivory Coast. After exposing government corruption, he was imprisoned in Maca Prison but continued to fight for a better future for his children.

Catherine's Story (Malawi)

After learning she was HIV-positive, Catherine Phiri went public and founded SASO to help others. Her work grew to support thousands of orphans and households, eventually gaining UN recognition.

Advocacy Action

Good advocacy involves:

1. **Understanding the Issues:** Learning as much as possible and finding allies.
2. **Building Interest:** Using posters, plays, debates, and the media.
3. **Setting Goals:** Identifying clear objectives and whom to influence.
4. **Getting Organised:** Creating an action plan.

Escalation Model of Advocacy Action

We recommend a gradual approach:

1. **Direct Engagement:** Compliments, assertive feedback, and clear requests.
2. **Report to Seniors:** Escalating to higher management or national departments.
3. **External Confrontation:** Legal action, media attention, or mass action.

Learning Activity 4.6: Write Your Own Success Story

Write down one success story you have had in protecting and promoting children's rights.

- Describe the right abused and what you did.
- Collect evidence of your actions.
- Explain how it changed lives.

Unit Summary

We are all responsible for realising children's rights across five levels: the child, family, community, partner institutions, and government. Through citizenship, civic participation, and advocacy, we can build a culture of respect for human rights and create lasting change.

Module Conclusion

We hope you are inspired to become agents of change. Go back to the Kibali story and see how your responses have changed with your new knowledge!

Table 1: Possible Roles of Government Offices in Child Protection

Department / Ministry	Possible Role in Child Protection
Office of the President	Makes sure that child protection issues are a priority
The Parliament	Makes sure that there are laws to protect children and makes sure children's rights are met
The Judiciary / Justice	Respects every child, creates child-friendly courts and procedures; makes sure that crimes are punished
Office of the Ombudsman	Fixes things when children's rights are abused in the public service; creates child-friendly places
Police	Protects children; finds criminals; does not treat victims as criminals
Ministry of Social Development	Has social workers and community development workers who help families access social protection
Ministry of Education	Makes sure children get a good education; prevents abuse by teachers or learners
Ministry of Health	Offers age/gender-appropriate care; cares for abused or neglected children; teaches families good care
Ministry of Finance	Makes sure that there is room in the budget for child protection issues
Ministry of Trade and Industry	Makes sure that children are not exploited, trafficked or otherwise abused for profit
Ministry of Agriculture	Makes sure that children are not exploited for farm labour; provides agricultural support to poor families
Central Statistics Office	Collects data to track children; highlights where rights are not met
Ministry of Labour	Makes sure work options exist for adults, but children are not exploited
Directorate on Corruption	Fights corruption and crime that affects children
Auditor General	Makes sure that resources are used correctly
Attorney General	Writes laws that bring national law in line with international treaties
Ministry of Youth and Culture	Advocates for children and youth; helps build skills for young people to participate in government
Ministry of Sports	Creates ways for children to enjoy play and leisure in a safe environment
Ministry of Women's Affairs	Improves the status of women and girls

Table 2: Knowledge, Skills, and Values for Citizenship

Knowledge	Skills	Values and Attitudes
Social justice for all; non-discrimination	Critical thinking	Sense of self and self-esteem
Role of UN, NGOs, and CBOs	Voicing concerns effectively	Understanding problems of vulnerable people
Effects of poverty, war, and disease	Making strong arguments; teamwork	Commitment to social justice and equality
	Problem-solving and goal-focus	Respect for differences; belief in collective action

Table 3: SYP Model Questionnaire for Youth Participation

Step	Attitude	Action	Approach
1. Listen	Do adults listen?	Is it possible to listen?	Actively listening
2. Facilitate	Are they able to speak?	Is it made easier?	Child-friendly materials
3. Include	Is their input in decisions?	Is it thought about carefully?	Accurate representation
4. Involve	Is there a real role?	Are there opportunities?	Shared decision making